Clash, Transformation, Replacement or Compartmentalization? Frame Disputes between Micro-Cohorts in the Refugee Solidarity Movement

Hjalmar Bang Carlsen and Jonas Toubøl

Abstract

The transformation of social movement collective identity—the shared understanding among members of the movement's purpose, goals, and means—is a central concern in social movement research. The micro-cohort theory suggests that when new cohorts of activists enter under different political conditions, frame disputes between newcomers and veterans will reshape the movement's collective identity. In this paper we further theorize the micro-cohort framework suggesting four scenarios of micro-cohort frame disputes: 1) Clash, 2) Transformation, 3) Replacement, and 4) Compartmentalization. We then deploy the framework to examine the Danish refugee solidarity movement, where the 2022 mobilization in solidarity with Ukrainian refugees brought in a large cohort of newcomers under radically different political conditions than the veteran cohort who in 2015 mobilized to support Syrian refugees. Using digital trace data from both mobilizations we estimate the overlap of activists and find that both cohorts are active in relation to Syrian refugees rejecting the replacement scenario. Our data reveals that while veterans and newcomers differ politically according to the expected moral logics animating each cohort–veterans defending universalist humanitarianism, and newcomers justifying conditional solidarity–we, surprisingly, we find very few instances of frame disputes rejecting the clash scenario, nor negotiations of a new collective identity rejecting the transformation scenario. Countering our expectations, we find that the veteran cohort compartmentalize their critique to veteran fora, while they in the newcomer fora focus on coordination of help to the Ukrainian refugees. The results confirm the salience of the micro cohort perspective and the usefulness of our theoretical extension of the framework and exemplifies how loosely organized movements' collective identity may rapidly alter due to the critical events and shifts in the public discourse.

Keywords: Collective identity, frame disputes, micro-cohorts, solidarity, Facebook

Introduction

The formation, endurance, and transformation of collective identity—the shared understanding among activists of their purpose, worldview, and means of action—are central concerns in social movement theory (Melucci 1989; Tilly 2005; Tarrow 2011). Although collective identity is inherently dynamic and continuously renegotiated through interaction (Melucci 1995; Coley 2015; Ganz 2020), movements are nevertheless understood to depend on sufficiently shared identities to sustain coordinated collective action (Snow et al. 1986; McAdam 1999; Passy and Monsch 2020). For this reason, internal struggles over meaning and direction have long been of particular interest to movement scholars. Benford (1993) conceptualizes such struggles as *frame disputes*—episodes in which activists contest how issues should be interpreted and acted upon. A central driver of these disputes, Whittier (1997) argues, is the entry of new micro-cohorts of activists whose political outlooks are shaped by formative events different from those experienced by veteran participants. When cohorts mobilized under divergent political conditions interact within the same movement, differences in interpretation and moral orientation are expected to surface as frame disputes, potentially reshaping the movement's collective identity and future trajectory (Seigler et al. 2025).

In this article, we examine a case in which this expectation is not borne out. Following Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022, a massive volunteer mobilization emerged in Denmark to support Ukrainian refugees. This mobilization brought together two distinct cohorts within the refugee solidarity movement: a veteran cohort first mobilized during the 2015 Syrian refugee crisis under restrictive and highly contentious asylum politics, and a newcomer cohort entering the movement in 2022 amid unusually broad public support and exceptional legal protections for Ukrainian refugees. The two cohorts differed sharply in their moral evaluations of refugee deservingness and in their assessments of the Danish state's differential treatment of refugees. Yet overt frame disputes within the core arenas of the 2022 mobilization were strikingly rare.

This empirical pattern poses a theoretical puzzle. If collective identity is necessary for sustaining coordinated action, how can a movement endure when its participants hold fundamentally

divergent moral framings of the issue at stake? Why did pronounced ideological differences between cohorts not escalate into overt frame disputes?

We address this puzzle by extending micro-cohort theory to specify four possible outcomes of interaction between veteran and newcomer cohorts with divergent frames: *clash*, *transformation*, *replacement*, and *compartmentalization*. The first three outcomes are well established in the literature. *Clash* refers to open frame disputes that produce internal factions (Benford 1993). *Transformation* occurs when such disputes culminate in the negotiation of a new shared collective identity (Melucci 1995). *Replacement* describes situations in which veteran activists disengage, allowing the newcomers' framing to become dominant (Whittier 1997, Hirschman 1970). We argue that these outcomes overlook a fourth and theoretically consequential possibility: *compartmentalization*. Lichterman and Eliasoph (2014) develop the concept to explain how distinct scene styles can coexist within political coalitions without escalating into overt frame disputes. Whereas they analyze compartmentalization as a patterned feature of civic interaction that enables pluralism across settings, we theorize it as a distinct pathway of micro-cohort interaction. Specifically, we show how compartmentalization can resolve the tensions predicted by micro-cohort theory by allowing cohort-based divergence to persist without escalating into clash, negotiated transformation, or exit. In this scenario, activists sustain divergent moral framings yet articulate them in separate interactional settings, leaving cross-cohort arenas of coordination largely free of overt frame disputes.

Our development of compartmentalization as a pathway of cohort interaction draws on interactionist and pragmatic perspectives emphasizing how moral expectations embedded in specific settings constrain what can be said and done (Goffman 1974; Eliasoph and Lichterman 2003; Boltanski and Thévenot 2006). Humanitarian movements are governed by a powerful moral imperative to alleviate suffering in the here and now. Frame disputes that risk disrupting this task may therefore be experienced as morally inappropriate, even when grounded in widely shared principles such as equality or universalism. As a result, activists may refrain from voicing critique in core movement arenas, instead articulating it in peripheral or cohort-specific spaces. Compartmentalization thus allows movements to sustain collective action despite unresolved moral disagreement, but at the cost of suppressing overt negotiation of collective identity.

We examine these micro-cohort dynamics through a mixed-method analysis of the Danish refugee solidarity movement, drawing posts and comments from Facebook groups active during the 2015 and 2022 mobilizations. Using name-matching across mobilizations, we identify veteran and newcomer activists and compare their participation patterns and political orientations. We combine this cohort mapping with qualitative analysis of in-situ interactions across movement arenas to assess when and where divergent moral framings were articulated. Despite pronounced ideological divergence between micro cohorts and continued veteran participation, we find no sustained clash, no evidence of cohort replacement, and no negotiation process leading to a transformation of collective identity within the movement's central arenas of coordination. Instead, critique of differential refugee treatment was largely confined to veteran-dominated or peripheral settings, leaving cross-cohort coordination free of overt frame disputes. This pattern is consistent with compartmentalization: cohort-based divergence persisted, but its articulation was displaced across interactional settings rather than resolved through clash, cohort replacement, or transformation.

Overall, this article builds on emerging work that brings micro-cohort turnover and within-movement conflict back to the center of social movement analysis. Recent contributions have illuminated cohort tensions primarily from an organizational vantage point—most notably by examining how leaders interpret and manage intra-organizational conflict. We shift the focus to rank-and-file dynamics as they unfold in the everyday arenas of mobilization. Using digital trace data that allow us to identify individuals across cycles of mobilization, we analyze micro-cohort continuity and turnover as participation trajectories, and we link these trajectories to cohorts' ideological profiles and to the articulation (and non-articulation) of competing frames within movement groups. This article makes three contributions. First, we refine micro-cohort theory by specifying compartmentalization as a distinct pathway through which cohort-based divergence can persist without escalating into clash, negotiated transformation, or exit. Second, we show how setting specific moral expectations shape whether ideological disagreement becomes an overt frame dispute, highlighting moral constraint as a key mechanism in micro-cohort interaction. Third, we demonstrate how individual-level digital trace data enable systematic observation of participation and interaction between cohorts across movement arenas, offering new leverage for studying the everyday negotiation, and suspension, of collective identity. Although centered on refugee solidarity, the argument generalizes to movements

organized under strong moral or organizational imperatives that constrain the articulation of internal conflict.

Outcomes of Micro-Cohort Frame Divergence: Clash, Transformation, Replacement, and Compartmentalization

Collective identities and movement frames are often treated as prerequisites for sustained collective action, yet they remain objects of ongoing interaction in which activists negotiate what an issue means and what action is appropriate (Taylor and Whittier 1992; Benford and Snow 2000; Melucci 1995). A key source of such renegotiation is cohort turnover. Micro-cohort theory argues that when new cohorts enter a movement under different political conditions, they bring interpretive orientations shaped by distinct "politicizing experiences," creating the potential for divergence in how group boundaries are drawn, how grievances are defined, and who counts as the relevant opponent (Whittier 1997). As Nancy Whittier puts it, "When changes occur in the contexts that shape cohorts' collective identities, recruits who enter the movement at different times have different politicising experiences and hence construct different collective identities" (Whittier 1997:763). Micro-cohort theory thus explains why veterans and newcomers may share a general commitment to a cause while carrying different moral logics and understandings of solidarity. Differences that can ultimately lead to cohort replacement where the veteran one cohort disengages and another comes to define the movement's collective identity.

Recent work underscores that cohort divergence can become a practical organizational problem. Carolina P. Seigler and colleagues (2025) trace political-generational conflict in U.S. LGBTQ+ organizations, showing that leaders experience generational turnover as "choppy waters" that forces strategic choices about inclusion, boundary maintenance, and organizational direction. Their contribution is to demonstrate how cohort differences become organizational problems that leaders handle in divergent ways, with some pursuing inclusive strategies and others responding through exclusion and boundary tightening. At the same time, this approach locates the dynamics primarily in leaders' accounts and organizational texts, leaving comparatively open how cohort divergence is enacted among rank-and-file participants in the everyday arenas where mobilization happens, and how those arenas shape whether divergence becomes visible as conflict, negotiated into compromise, or remains unspoken.

To connect cohort divergence to observable within-movement interaction, we turn to Benford's (1993) concept of *frame disputes*. Frame disputes are episodes in which activists explicitly contest interpretive and strategic commitments. They are not simply differences in opinion, they are articulated disagreements between movement members. Benford's framework also clarifies that disputes can occur at different organizational levels (e.g., between organizations or within them) and need not map neatly onto stable factions. But when dispute alignments repeatedly track cohort lines, veterans contesting newcomers(or vice versa), frame disputes become a plausible mechanism through which micro-cohort divergence can result in movement fractions(cite alle the fraction literature+stiegler som også har det som pointe).

Drawing distinction between the different outlook held by veteran and newcomer cohorts and actual frame disputes enables us to ask when cohort divergence turns into sustained dispute and when it does not. When participants perceive misalignment between their commitments and dominant practices, they may respond through *voice*, *exit*, or *loyalty* (Hirschman 1970). Voice entails articulating critique in an attempt to redirect the collective trajectory; exit entails disengagement from the collective project (or from its key arenas); and loyalty entails continued participation while withholding dissent. This repertoire helps specify why the same underlying divergence can produce different trajectories.

Crucially, however, voice, exit, and loyalty are not enacted under uniform conditions across a movement. The feasibility and costs of disputing depend on where participants interact. To capture this variation, we draw on interactionist work emphasizing that settings carry distinctive norms of appropriateness that shape what kinds of talk are possible (Goffman 1974; Eliasoph and Lichterman 2003). Following Lichterman and Eliasoph (2014), we conceptualize movements as composed of multiple *scenes*: interactional settings with recognizable styles of engagement that organize coordination and constrain critique. Scenes may be anchored in organizations, meetings, Facebook groups, or personal profiles, but what makes them analytically distinctive is their interactional order: what participants treat as legitimate topics, how disagreement is handled, and which moral expectations govern participation.

Scene styles difference relation to critique and contention is central in humanitarian movements(Author+ Boltanski). In scenes oriented toward immediate relief, political critique that risks disrupting care can be treated as morally inappropriate. The imperative to "help here and now" constrains what can be voiced without appearing divisive, self-interested, or exploitative of beneficiaries' suffering(Boltanski). That is humanitarian activism contention can be seen as jeopardizing operations and thereby treated as a moral transgression against the very people activists aim to support (Toubøl 2017; Fernández G. G. 2023; Carlsen and Toubøl 2022). Under such conditions, activists may sustain cohort-based divergence without articulating it in the very scenes where cross-cohort coordination is most vital. We therefore distinguish between coordination-central scenes, where humanitarian logistics and assistance are organized, and coordination-peripheral scenes, where participation is less directly tied to the immediate work of relief and where moral evaluation and political disagreement may be more permissible.

Taken together, micro-cohort theory and scene-specific constraints imply four analytically distinct outcomes of micro-cohort interaction. Each corresponds to a different configuration of voice, exit, and loyalty—and to a different distribution of disagreement across the movement's scene ecology.

Clash: Cohort-based disagreement can surface as frame disputes in any scene, including peripheral or cohort-specific ones. But it becomes consequential for a movement's trajectory when it is voiced and sustained in scenes central to the movements coordination. In such cases, dispute can escalate into clash: overt frame disputes marked by repeated sequences of challenge and counter-justification over core moral commitments can polarize participants and generate factions (Benford 1993). Empirically, clash is indicated by recurring disputes and boundary work in coordination-central scenes about who belongs, what solidarity requires, the larger purpose of the movement.

Transformation: Voice does not always fracture movements; under some conditions it yields compromise and convergence. Transformation occurs when disputes, whether sparked in central or peripheral scenes, are carried into coordination-central scenes and culminate in a negotiated settlement that produces a reworked collective identity shared across cohorts (Melucci 1995). Empirically, transformation is indicated by visible bridging work across framings and the

emergence of a new shared vocabulary or principle that becomes authoritative in coordination-central scenes.

Replacement: When the dominant response is exit rather than voice, veteran activists disengage from the scenes that anchor the new mobilization instead of contesting its dominant framing. In this case, collective identity shifts through compositional change: the newcomers' interpretive orientation becomes dominant not because it persuades veterans, but because veterans withdraw (Whittier 1997; Hirschman 1970). Empirically, replacement is indicated by declining veteran participation in coordination-central scenes and the fading presence of veteran framings without sustained dispute in those scenes.

Compartmentalization: Finally, cohort divergence may persist without escalating into overt disputes when loyalty is enacted in coordination-central scenes and voice is redirected to coordination-peripheral scenes. In this scenario, activists sustain divergent moral framings but differentially articulate them across scenes: critique is voiced in peripheral scenes—older solidarity groups, cohort-specific forums, or personal profiles—while central scenes remain oriented toward practical coordination and constrained forms of talk (Lichterman and Eliasoph 2014). Compartmentalization is not the absence of disagreement; it is the scene-specific organization of disagreement. Its empirical signature is an uneven distribution of critique and dispute across scenes rather than their resolution through clash, negotiated transformation, or cohort exit from the movement as a whole.

These outcomes clarify what is at stake in analyzing frame disputes between micro-cohorts. The key question is not only whether cohorts differ, but whether—and in which scenes—those differences become interactionally consequential. In the analysis that follows, we therefore combine cohort identification and measures of participation and political orientation with qualitative analysis of in-situ interaction across distinct scenes. This design allows us to evaluate whether the 2022 mobilization exhibits clash, transformation, replacement, or compartmentalization, and to specify how scene-specific moral constraints shape the pathways through which cohort frame divergence does, or does not, reconfigure collective identity.

Data and method

Key to the current analysis are four types of data: 1) text data on the articulation of frames by movement members, 2) information identifying the cohort to which each member belongs, 3) participation rates of the respective cohorts, and 4) the political leanings of each cohort. Taken together, these data allow us to assess whether the 2022 mobilization exhibits frame clash, transformation, cohort replacement, or frame compartmentalization.

Facebook group data from the 2015 and 2022 mobilizations (Carlsen, Gårdhus, and Toubøl 2022; Carlsen, Toubøl, and Ralund 2021b) provide rich information on the first three dimensions. For both periods, we have access to internal group interactions, including posts, comments, comment threads, and reactions. To measure the political leaning of each cohort, we link movement members to an external dataset capturing public "likes" of Danish parliamentary politicians. In what follows, we detail the collection of each dataset, describe our name-matching strategy for identifying veteran members within the 2022 mobilization, outline the data and measures used to infer each cohort's political orientation, and finally present our qualitative sampling strategies for analyzing frame articulation.

Sampling of Facebook Groups

We collected refugee solidarity Facebook groups in two waves, in 2016 and 2022, using comparable but distinct sampling strategies. In 2016, we aimed to identify a broad set of groups providing humanitarian or political support for refugees, relying on extensive keyword searches and manual snowball sampling, which yielded 165 groups (Carlsen, Toubøl, and Ralund 2021a; Toubøl 2017). In 2022, our focus shifted to groups that emerged specifically in response to the war in Ukraine. Observations from the 2015 sample indicated that most activity related to Ukrainian refugees occurred in newly formed, Ukraine-focused groups. We therefore conducted two searches using the Facebook search function: a general search for national groups using the term "ukraine help" (Danish: *ukraine hjælp*), and a locational search combining "Ukraine" with all Danish postal-code place names (581 queries). These searches produced approximately 800 distinct groups, of which 128 were identified as Ukraine help or solidarity groups (Carlsen, Gårdhus, and Toubøl 2022).

Facebook group data, matching strategy and measure of political leaning

From the 2022 mobilization, we collected all posts and comments from public Facebook groups related to refugee solidarity, totaling 110,194 messages between February 21, the day before the Russian invasion of Ukraine, and May 1, 2022. Based on this activity, we defined movement membership through active participation, resulting in a list of 19,636 members. Users who merely reacted to content or were passive group members are not included in this measure of movement membership. To determine whether participants were veterans (active in 2015) or newcomers, we matched usernames across the 2015 and 2022 mobilizations. The 2015 dataset contained 87,455 members, which we compared to the 2022 list. To ensure accuracy, we included only names unique within each dataset, excluding non-unique entries. Matching was performed using an exact character-level criterion (e.g., "Jan Hansen" ≠ "Jan B. Hansen"). This conservative approach minimizes both false positives and true positives and likely underestimates the actual overlap between cohorts. [Report on the final matching numbers.]

To measure political leaning, we draw on a large Facebook dataset containing user-level "like" activity on posts by all Danish parliamentary politicians from 2010 to 2018. This dataset provides each user's distribution of likes across political parties. We construct a left–right ideology measure based on a ranked list of parties ordered from most to least left-wing using two criteria. The primary criterion is each party's stance on immigration and refugee policy; when two parties are equally supportive or critical of immigration, we use their positions on economic redistribution as a secondary criterion. This procedure yields the following ranking on the left–right scale: Red–Green Alliance (1), The Alternative (2), Socialist People's Party (3), Danish Social Liberal Party (4), Social Democrats (5), Liberal Alliance (6), Conservative People's Party (7), Liberal Party (Venstre) (8), Danish People's Party (9). Each user's political leaning is then calculated as the mean value of the parties they have liked on this left–right scale. For each user i, we compute the mean of the left–right values of the parties they like:

$$LR_i = \frac{1}{N_i} \sum_{k=1}^{N_i} value_{ik}$$

where N_i is the total number of likes by user i and $value_{ik}$ is the 1–9 score of the party associated with like k.

Qualitative sampling strategies

Our qualitative analysis of movement frames draws on multiple complementary sampling strategies. To ensure a grounded understanding of the mobilization's activity and discourse, we conducted an online ethnography of several of the most central Facebook groups active during the 2022 mobilization. This provided a contextual understanding of helping practices, coordination tasks, and interactional styles within the groups. To increase the likelihood of identifying contrasting frames, we used the *provisional law* as a critical event that elicited divergent responses from activists and illuminated underlying moral positions. This strategy follows established approaches in controversy analysis (Venturini 2010), ethnomethodology (Garfinkel 1996), and French pragmatism (Boltanski and Thévenot 2006), all of which treat conflict and controversy as revealing cases for the study of morality in social life. We searched for posts and comments containing the term *provisional law* (Danish: "særlov") to locate moral disputes that were otherwise rare in the dataset. Posts and comments expressing either critique or justification of the differential treatment of refugees were analyzed in depth, focusing on the arguments and moral logics constituting the framing of the Ukrainian refugee situation. Online netnography poses a generalization challenge: without reading all posts, it's unclear if findings from a non-random sample support within case generalization. To generalize to the entire population, we coded 1,400 randomly sampled posts and comments for critique of differential refugee treatment. Identifying cohort membership was more challenging. During fieldwork, we inferred participants' cohort affiliation from self-descriptions and visible group memberships when possible. While our primary analysis centers on the newly formed groups from the 2022 mobilization, we also monitored veteran groups established during the 2015 mobilization to provide a comparative point of reference for interpreting differences in framing and discourse.

Politicization Contexts and Cohort Formation (2015 vs. 2022)

Denmark's two recent cycles of refugee solidarity mobilization unfolded in sharply different political situations, generating distinct politicization experiences for the cohorts they recruited (Whittier 1997). In 2015, the arrival of large numbers of Syrians coincided with an intensifying deterrence paradigm and a xenophobic political turn (Gammeltoft-Hansen and Hathaway 2015; Gammeltoft-Hansen and Tan 2017; Rytter et al. 2023). Mainstream politicians pursued restrictive measures that became visible symbols of exclusion, refugees were housed in former prisons and tent camps, and the "jewelry act" authorized confiscation of valuables above €1,500

(Gammeltoft-Hansen 2017). Against this backdrop, the refugee solidarity movement nevertheless mobilized at scale. More than 100,000 participants organized through Facebook groups (Agustín and Bak Jørgensen 2018; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019). Yet the contentious political climate forced the movement to justify even basic humanitarian engagement. The dominant faction, *The Friendly People*, articulated a depoliticized frame: volunteers should not consider "why the asylum seekers are here or IF they should be here," but simply treat them with "ordinary humanity and decency." Many groups explicitly banned political discussion to maintain broad participation and to avoid confrontation with xenophobic rhetoric and restrictive policies (Toubøl 2017). This depoliticized stance enabled mobilization in a hostile environment but also underscored the defensive position of the humanitarian movement.

The 2022 mobilization in support of Ukrainians unfolded under nearly opposite conditions. Public and parliamentary responses were unusually supportive, and Parliament rapidly adopted a provisional law granting Ukrainian refugees substantially more favorable rights and conditions than other refugee groups. These contrasting politicization experiences are expected to generate cohort-specific framings of solidarity and deservingness (Whittier 1997). In 2022 the defining dilemma was not whether helping was legitimate, but which refugees were entitled to equal treatment. Although the provisional law realized long-standing demands for more humane reception, it applied only to Ukrainians, challenging the veteran cohort's universalist principle that "a refugee is a refugee." The law's justification, framed in terms of regional proximity and cultural affinity, implicitly excluded Syrians and other non-European refugees from deserving equal protections. Some politicians even invoked religious difference to legitimate the discrepancy (e.g. Andersen 2022). This framing also altered the composition of the movement. The overwhelmingly positive public discourse surrounding Ukrainian refugees mobilized new segments of the population, some of whom viewed Ukrainians as uniquely deserving compared to refugees from the Middle East or Africa. As a result, the 2022 mobilization introduced internal tensions between veteran activists committed to universalism and newcomers whose support was more conditional. These conditions create a central question: how cross-cohort coordination is sustained when frame divergence over deservingness is a prominent feature of the movement?

Overlaps and ideological difference between micro-cohorts

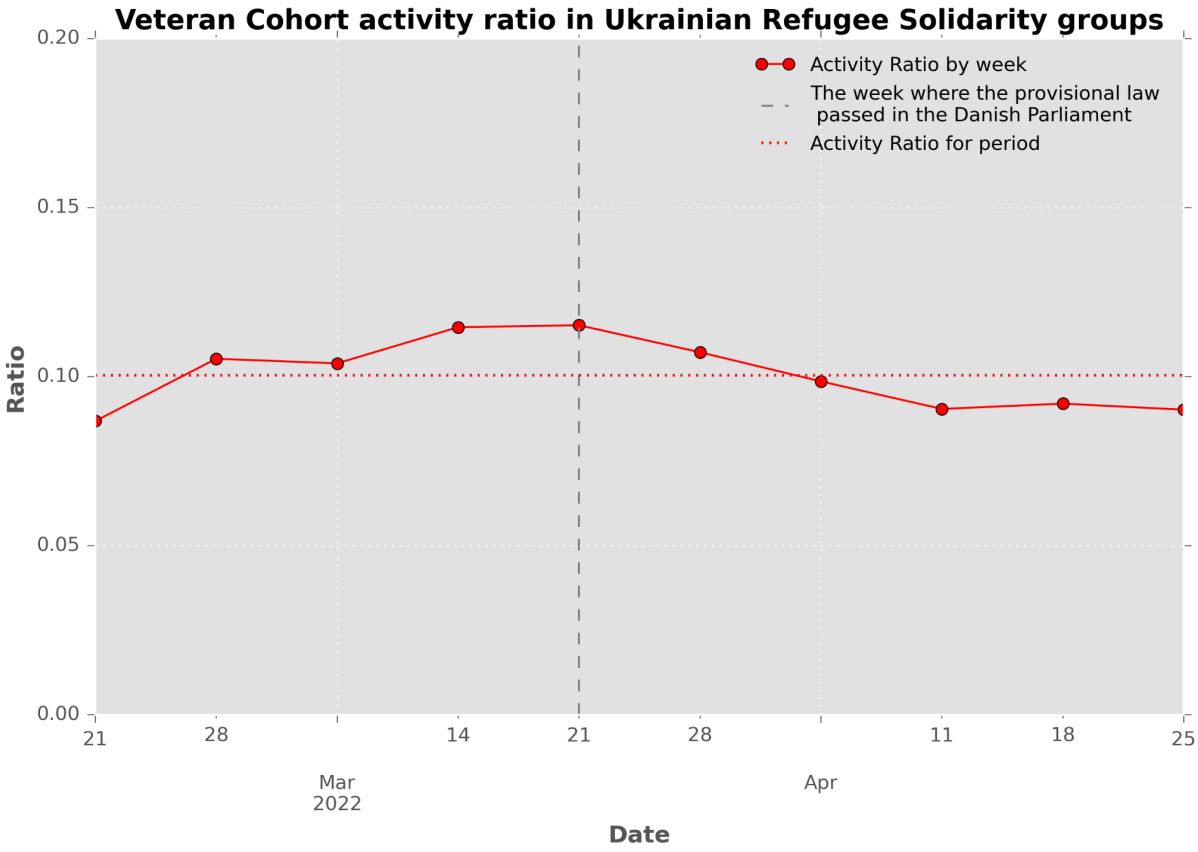
In this section, we investigate two basic assumptions that must be met for an analysis of frame disputes between micro-cohorts to be meaningful. The first assumption concerns whether multiple cohorts are present and actively participating in the mobilization of solidarity toward Ukrainian refugees. If there is near-complete overlap or complete non-overlap between activists from previous and current mobilizations, then distinct cohorts cannot be said to exist, and no frame disputes between them would be possible. We refer to the first scenario as *cohort reproduction* and the second as *cohort replacement*. The second assumption concerns whether the two cohorts exhibit different political ideologies. If their political outlooks are very similar, we would expect a smooth merger of the micro-cohorts, resulting in the successful negotiation of a new, shared collective identity for the movement, making frame disputes unlikely. Conversely, if their political orientations differ markedly, we would expect outcomes along the lines hypothesized above: *clash, transformation, cohort replacement, or compartmentalization.*

Cohort composition of the Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups

Were any veteran activists from the 2015 Syria refugee crisis active in the newly formed Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups in 2022? Using our Facebook name-matching method, we estimate that approximately 9.5 percent of participants in the 2022 Ukrainian solidarity groups had also been active in the 2015 Syrian refugee mobilization (see Table 1 in the appendix).

To assess the cohorts' relative activity levels, we calculated the average number of posts and comments per user as well as the average length of their messages. The veteran cohort was slightly more active on both measures, which is unsurprising given that prior activism is a strong predictor of future engagement (McAdam 1986; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019). Figure 1 shows that veterans were consistently active throughout the sampled period, accounting for roughly 10 percent of all activity in the Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups. The vertical line marks the week in which the provisional law was passed; although veteran activity declined slightly thereafter, it remained substantial. These patterns indicate that both cohorts were active participants in the 2022 mobilization. In other words, the mobilization did not involve a complete *cohort replacement*.

Figure 1. Veteran Cohort Activity Ratio in Ukrainian Refugee Solidarity Groups



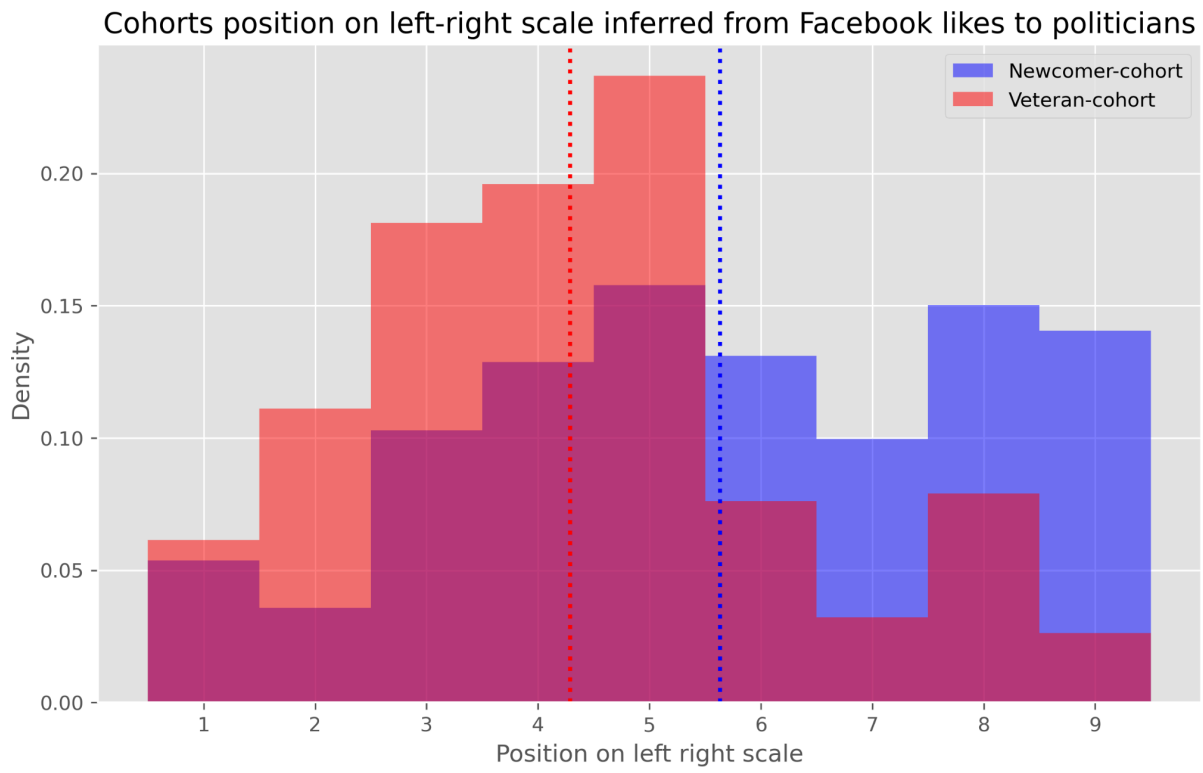
Note: The figure presents the weekly activity ratio of the veteran cohort in Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups on Facebook from late February to April 2022. The y-axis represents the proportion of total activity (posts and comments) attributable to veteran members, while the x-axis shows the timeline in weeks. The solid red line with circular markers represents the weekly activity ratio, and the horizontal dotted red line indicates the average activity ratio for the period. A vertical dashed gray line marks the week in which the Danish Parliament passed a provisional law giving refugees from the Ukraine favorable treatment in comparison to other refugee groups.

The cohorts' political ideological orientation

Turning to differences in political ideology between the two cohorts, Figure 2 displays the distribution of their positions on the left–right scale. Although there is considerable overlap in

the ideological profiles of the two groups, the newcomer cohort has a much larger share of users on the political right (mean = 5.63), including the far right, which is a stronghold of anti-refugee sentiment. By contrast, the veteran cohort has a large share of its members on the political left (mean = 4.29). It is also noteworthy that a substantial segment of the newcomer cohort is as left-leaning as the veterans.

Figure 2. Activist cohorts position on-left-right scale



Note. The figure shows the distribution of users' inferred ideological positions on a 1–9 left–right scale (1 = most left-leaning, 9 = most right-leaning) for the newcomer (blue) and veteran (red) cohorts, based on their Facebook likes of politicians. Bars show normalized histograms (density) for each cohort, and vertical dotted lines indicate the mean position within each cohort.

It should be noted that extreme right-wing ideological orientations are rare in both cohorts and the difference in mean score is a result of the veteran-cohort gravitating towards the left while the newcomer-cohort both have members oriented towards center-left positions as well as a strong presence of members oriented towards a moderate center-right position. Thus, the two cohorts do seem to me mobilized from relatively different parts of the Danish

political-ideological landscape which means we should expect frame disputes to be present in the Ukraine refugee solidarity groups.

Concluding from this quantitative analysis of the different activity and political profiles of the cohort, we can conclude that we have two different cohorts active within support groups and that these groups have a significantly different political ideology.

The micro-cohorts' frame disputes

The following exemplary quote of frame disputes between the cohorts is drawn from an online conversation in one of the Ukrainian support groups:

> Katrine: "Ukrainian refugees have been received with goodwill, a provisional law, and open arms. That is how it should be, in my opinion. However, refugees from other wars in the world have in the last couple of years been received with distrust, populist legislation, and closed doors, and that is unacceptable from our side."
>
> Peter: "Those that come from Ukraine have a wish to come home as fast as possible. They are also in jobs quickly; they recognize our way of living in this country. They become a part of the society they live in. The others [Ed: foreigners] do not want to work. They just want. They do not recognize our way of living."
>
> Martin: "@Peter: What are you doing here? Long live racism."
>
> Dan: "@Martin: What are you doing here yourself."

In the exchange, Katrine expresses support for the positive reception of Ukrainian refugees, describing it as "with goodwill, a provisional law, and open arms." She then makes an explicit comparison to how other refugee groups have been received—with "distrust, populist legislation, and closed doors"—and deems this contrast "unacceptable." Katrine appears to be referring both to political legislation and, though less clearly, to popular opinion. Her attitude and argument are consistent with the moral outlook of the refugee solidarity movement during prior waves of mobilization. Katrine's comment exemplifies the veteran cohort's response to and evaluation of the provisional law. At its core is a frame grounded in the principle of universal and equal rights, often captured by the phrase *a refugee is a refugee*. In the following section, we detail the veteran cohort's reactions to the provisional law, showing how it became a focal point for highlighting the unjust differential treatment of refugees and, in some cases, was denounced as racist legislation.

We then turn to the newcomers' frame. Some newcomers openly sought to justify the provisional law and the differential treatment of refugees. We interpret this as a deservingness frame, in which newcomers applied deservingness criteria to argue why Ukrainian refugees should receive better treatment than refugees from other regions. In this view, access to help is not universal but conditional. This position is exemplified by Peter in the conversation above. Replying to Katrine, he justified the differential treatment by appealing to cultural similarity ("they understand our way of living") and willingness to contribute ("in jobs quickly"), while contrasting this with his perception that other refugee groups "just want." This frame stands in stark opposition to that of the veteran cohort.

The ideological difference created clear grounds for potential frame disputes. Martin, for instance, challenged Peter's comment by questioning why he was part of the group at all, ironically concluding "Long live racism." A fourth member, Dan, then intervened to ask Martin what *he* was doing in the group. These exchanges reveal not only divergent moral evaluations of differential treatment but also conflicting convictions about what defines group membership and solidarity itself. In principle, such differences provide multiple reasons to expect frame disputes between cohorts.

Yet, when examining the broader activity across groups, we find almost no trace of such disputes within the Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups. Most critique from veteran activists was voiced elsewhere—in groups established during earlier mobilizations—rather than in the spaces central to coordinating support for Ukrainians. Instead of clash, transformation, or cohort replacement, the dominant dynamic was one of *compartmentalization*. In the concluding analysis, we discuss the reasons why activists refrained from articulating their critiques in coordination forums, thereby effectively avoiding open frame disputes.

The veteran cohort's framing—the critique of the Ukraine privilege

Many from the veteran cohort, both in terms of single individuals and groups active before the 2022 mobilization, are critical of the state's differential treatment of refugees, evident from the harsh critique they launched against the provisional law.

Initially, there was a hope that the Ukrainian refugee situation would create a political opportunity to change the Danish asylum law because the Ukrainian refugees unveiled all the most problematic features of both Danish and EU asylum policies. Actors in the movement were

quick to emphasize this agenda. For instance, one of the most central NGOs, Refugees Welcome, stated, “The current crisis situation clearly demonstrates that there is a need for a decent Danish asylum policy, more convergence in rules in the EU, and an effective and fair distribution key.[1]” To begin with, it also seems likely that many new Danish refugee activists would turn toward a critique of the asylum system and the government because the regulation undermined their humanitarian efforts. In the early phase, before the provisional law, Refugees Welcome sent out a pamphlet entitled “How would Ukrainians' situations be in Denmark? The short answer is: bad,[2]” warning Ukrainians against coming to Denmark due to the country's particularly restrictive regulation. The pamphlet lists various legal reasons why Ukrainian refugees would be worse off in Denmark compared to other EU countries. This created uncertainty in many groups and a growing sense of the regulation being too restrictive. However, the provisional law displaced this critical situation that could unite large parts of the population in a collective critique of the reigning asylum politics. After the government announced their plans for a provincial law, volunteers referred to this extensively to provide certainty for activists that they would be able to ensure proper conditions for the Ukrainian refugees.

The provisional law partly undermined the political opportunity for contentious mobilization, and this was the case because it supported many in their immediate humanitarian efforts and ensured much better conditions for the Ukrainian refugees. Instead of uniting the cohorts, the provisional law created a split within the refugee solidarity movement between the veteran cohort of refugee solidarity activists mobilized and shaped in relation to prior waves of refugees in the context of a radically different and very hostile political climate, and the new cohort of refugee activists dedicated to helping Ukrainian refugees here and now enjoying the widespread support from leaders across the political spectrum and the general population's positive attitude (Hedegaard and Larsen 2022).

The core principle guiding many from the veteran cohort was frequently expressed by the phrase “a refugee is a refugee,” suggesting that the rights of refugees are universal, and all

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[1] “Den nuværende krisesituation viser med al tydelighed, at der er behov for en anstændig dansk asylpolitik, mere ensartede regler i EU, og en effektiv og fair fordelingsnøgle.” https://www.facebook.com/refugeeswelcomedenmark/posts/7172446619492161, visited 2023-01-03.

[2] https://www.facebook.com/refugeeswelcomedenmark/photos/a.782330581837162/7154069487996541, visited 2023-01-03.

refugees should be treated with the same dignity and care. The fact that European, Christian, and light-skinned refugees had more political support than refugees with a darker skin tone, Muslim faith, and origin in the Middle East or Africa violated many of the veteran cohort's universal humanitarian ideals. Thus, their framing of the situation around the provisional law articulated accusations of racism and discrimination on the basis of the principle of common humanity, which had been replaced by differential treatment of refugees making access to help and protection conditional on their origin.

The newcomer cohort's framing: Justifying the differential treatment

For the newcomers, the provisional law's first and most prominent justification is that it enables refugee support in times of crisis. Yet, this is a limited justification of the law, pertaining more to planned action where actors are concerned with reaching a specific goal and not justifying the moral logic underpinning the law. The more principled justification revolves around three overall arguments: 1) a difference in situation, 2) a difference in regional proximity, and lastly, 3) a difference in the type of refugee.

The first set of arguments concerns the difference in the situation between the war in Syria and the war in Ukraine. This argument holds that 1) the antagonist is more pronounced in the war in Ukraine, where the State of Russia represent a unified, easily identifiable perpetrator, compared to the complex civil war in Syria. 2) Ukraine and Western countries are allied in the conflict against Russia, where Ukrainians carry by far the highest costs and therefore deserve support. As one member puts it, responding to a critique of the provisional law privileging refugees from Ukraine: "Russia attacked Ukraine; it's not a civil war. If Russia wins it, they will likely continue to Poland….Ukraine is fighting for the other nations that do not dare to go to war." In a later comment, the same member states, "If it was a civil war in Ukraine, no one would help, just as in Syria." These comments are not merely an analysis of the political situation but arguments that seek to justify the Ukrainian privilege because they occur as responses to the critique of Ukrainian privilege. They function as modes of disarming critique.

A second argument concerns the geographical proximity of Denmark and Ukraine. The Social Democratic government clearly saw the provisional law as a natural extension of their principle that humanitarian relief for refugees should happen in the local region. This justification was also used when implementing policies to keep refugees away from Denmark in

the Syrian refugee crisis. Some activists in the Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups also took up the geographical argument. As one activist argues in response to a critique of discrimination:

"The critique underlines the tasteless and historically ignorant tendencies in the debate about foreigners. Especially those who think we give special treatment to Ukrainians, because they are Christian, white, or European. No, what we are doing is to take responsibility in our local region." *Newcomer activist*

According to this activist, critics of the so-called Ukrainian privilege have misunderstood the situation. In their view, privileging Ukrainians has nothing to do with religion, race, or European identity, but rather with geographical proximity. Another activist elaborated: *"It is fine that people fled from the war back then [the war in Syria]. But there are many regional countries that can help better locally. Just like we now do locally. That is why I call it neighborhood help."* The justifications for Ukrainian privilege varied in tone and intensity. At times, the counter-critique was forceful, dismissing opposing views as "tasteless and historically ignorant tendencies." At other times, it was more measured, but nonetheless firmly defended the legitimacy of treating Ukrainian refugees differently.

Lastly, there is the justification of Ukrainian privilege that refers to a difference in the type of refugees. Many of the criteria used to justify discriminating between Ukrainian and other refugees, especially Middle Eastern, can be described with reference to the central criteria in deservingness theory, namely *control* (less control, more deserving), *need* (the greater the need, the more deserving), *identity* (the closer to 'us,' the more deserving), *attitude* (the more compliant, the more deserving), and *reciprocity* (the more reciprocation, the more deserving) (Oorschot 2000, 2006). In addition, some arguments go beyond these criteria and stress the loyalty and bravery of the Ukrainian people.

With regard to the *need* of the refugees, activists refer to the age and gender of the refugees. Ukrainian refugees are women and kids, whereas other refugees typically are men traveling ahead to secure routes and destinations for their families. Another set of arguments regards the difference in *attitude*: "The Ukrainians show great gratitude and don't want to be a burden. The others demanded and demanded and did not want to conform. They might now learn that it would help them to have another attitude." Another activist activates the identity criteria of

cultural proximity to assert the *un*deservingness of the Syrian refugees compared to the Ukrainians when writing, “Their [the Syrian refugees] religion might fit in in the middle east, but not here.” One might suspect that a hostile attitude toward Muslim refugees is a highly peripheral position in the groups. However, judging from both the number of critical comments of other refugees and the distribution of likes between those who critique discrimination and those who justify it, it seems that this position is not a marginal position within the groups of Ukrainian refugee solidarity activists. A last contrast that is drawn between especially Syrian and Ukrainian refugees is that the latter men have stayed and are fighting against the Russian invasion, while the Syrian men fled from the war. As one member put it: “The Ukrainian men stayed home and fought👍👍; the Syrian men did not 👎.” On multiple accounts, the perceived Ukrainian loyalty and bravery were used to justify privileging this group of refugees.

The new cohort's justification of the differential treatment did not have the same unity in its frame as the veteran cohort. However, it does seem to draw upon logics of responsibility—the Danish population is responsible for refugees only in its geographical region—and logics of deservingness—not all refugees are equally deserving of our help. Both these logics have seldom been activated in the veteran cohort to justify helping some and not other refugees; hence, it seems to constitute a shift in the framing of the refugee solidarity movement.

Why so little frame dispute? Compartmentalizing the refugee solidarity movement

Despite the sample of critical and justificatory from which the above quotes are drawn, to our surprise, such exchanges were rare within the Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups. As clarified above, theoretically, we should expect frame disputes: There are two different cohorts with very different values and framings of the refugee issue. In addition, we have major political events (the passing of the provisional law), which precisely attenuated the cohorts’ differences and the likelihood of a clash. However, we see very few frame disputes. Why?

The most obvious reason is that very little of the critique of the provisional law and its discriminatory implications was expressed in the newly formed groups supporting Ukrainian refugees. During our online netnography, we identified some instances by searching for posts likely to contain such content—for example, those mentioning the provisional law—but these were far fewer than expected. Instead, most of this critique occurred in veteran groups formed during the 2015 mobilization in solidarity with Syrian refugees. However, these groups were not

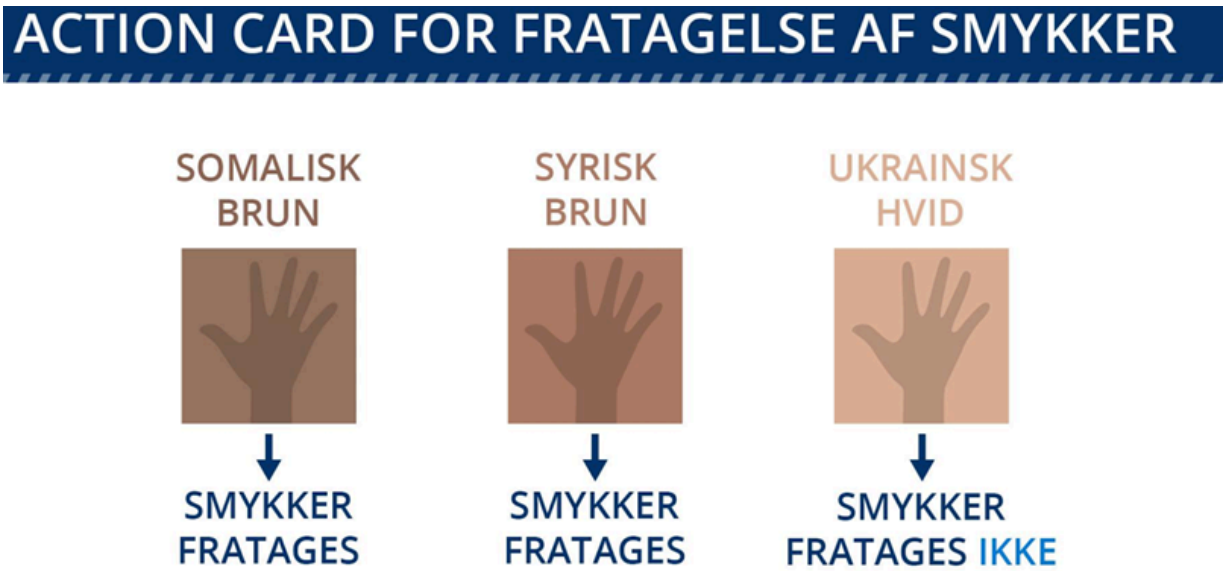
central to the organization of support for Ukrainian refugees in 2022. As a result, there were few occasions for frame disputes, since the new cohort was largely absent from the veteran groups.

A key concern is whether our findings generalize across the 110,000 messages within the refugee solidarity groups. To test this, we coded a random sample of 1,400 posts and comments and found zero instances of critique of discriminatory treatment. Using a Wilson score interval, we estimate the true proportion is below 0.27%, suggesting such critique is extremely rare—fewer than 3 in 1,000 posts.

As shown by the membership overlap analysis above, veteran cohort members constituted a substantial 9.5% of participants in the newly formed Ukrainian support groups. Yet, in many cases, they did not express their critiques within these groups. In the Ukrainian support forums, the same individuals could explain in detail how the provisional law addressed practical concerns about assisting Ukrainian refugees—while in other spaces, they authored extensive, fundamental critiques of the law as racist exemplifying what Lichterman and Eliasoph (2014) describe as the compartmentalization of scene styles.

The compartmentalized criticisms were both expressed in the forms of short, immediate commentaries like “Today, politicians voted for Apartheid in Denmark” and in more elaborate and graphical forms aiming to go viral. Figure 4 and 5 shows two examples of more elaborate critiques circulated in the veteran fora and on their personal profiles.

Figure 4. Widely circulated graphic among veterans criticising differential treatment of groups if refugees



The text translates to: "Action Card for confiscation of jewelry. Somali brown → Confiscate jewelry; Syrian brown → Confiscate jewelry; Ukrainian white → Do not confiscate jewelry"

Figure 4 is a widely circulated imagined "action card" for when to confiscate refugees' jewelry at the border referring to the jewelry act (Gammeltoft-Hansen 2017) from which Ukrainian refugees were exempt which the action card frame as expressing a racist logic by instructing to use the skincolor of the refugee to decide when to confiscate jewelry. Similarly, the post in figure 5 from a veteran social media group sarcastically ascertains that current practice apparently openly discriminates between groups of refugees and receives a supportive comment confirming and reinforcing the shared sense of injustices among the activists. Our online ethnography revealed that such expressions of criticism among the veterans was quite common during this period despite being rare in the Ukrainian refugee solidarity groups.

Figure 5. Post from veteran facebook group criticising the differential treatment of refugees

Translation of the post and comment: Post: ”By the way, one must understand that in Denmark there are refugees. And then there are refugees. Some get a train ticket and may keep their wedding ring. Other must walk the high way and hand over the gold (and the dignity) by…; Comment: “It is simply unbearable.”

One exception to this compartmentalization was when the provisional law was celebrated within the Ukrainian refugee groups without any practical context. A short celebratory statement around the law sparked a critical situation where critiques and justifications of the law emerged. One activist writes in a comment, “Very good for the Ukrainians. Very bad for our refugees from the Middle East who AGAIN have to experience that they are the lowest ranked humans in Denmark.” The comment critiques Denmark in a rather explicit manner for discriminating against refugees coming from the Middle East. This critique sparked debate. One reaction was that the activists should celebrate this victory and work to extend the law to more groups of refugees. Others justified the differential treatment of the refugees.

A third reaction critiques the critique and clarifies the dilemmas of critiquing asylum politics in the Ukrainian refugee crisis. This latter ‘critique of critique’ illuminates why many from the veteran cohort might refrain from articulating a critique in the settings central to coordinating humanitarian relief. A common critique of critique during humanitarian crises is that the critic is exploiting the situation for self-interested political reasons (Boltanski 1998). This critique of critique arguably has a stronger position when activists seek to critique asylum politics generally, which refers to other refugees who are comparatively worse off. In response to the above critique of the provisional law, an activist writes: “Stop using unfortunate Ukrainian women and children to promote your own political standpoint!”. This statement clearly seeks, in Boltanski and Thévenot's (2006) language, to particularize critique and unveil it as self-interestedness, promoting personal political views. The critique, instead of helping, takes advantage of the situation to push its political agenda, namely the alleged injustice of the general Danish asylum and immigration policies to which all other groups of refugees are subjected. This, however, implies a shift of focus from one group of unfortunates to another, which is not in any obvious way a part of the crisis situations that activists are trying to deal with here and now. Hence, they both have to shift the attention from one situation to another and shift the mode of engagement from humanitarian relief action to contention. Furthermore, they must do this in a crisis that calls for immediate humanitarian action. Although the comparison between the Ukrainian refugees and the Syrian refugees, in principle, provides an advantageous position for the critique of discrimination, the simultaneous switch in both forms of engagement and situation is hard to accomplish. The temporal criticality in the humanitarian situations seems to overrule

the moral-logical injustice of the lack of equality between groups of refugees because relieving the suffering here and now takes precedence.

In addition to these situational constraints to critique in the current situation, the fundamental moral principle guiding much humanitarian activism—the sacredness of the suffering human (Durkheim 1975; Joas 2013)—also constrains critique. Refugee solidarity activism is tied to the well-being of particular refugees, and caring for the refugees is the most central component of the movement's collective identity, its raison d'etre. Thus, a major moral transgression is to sacrifice the well-being of concrete refugees for a greater political cause (Toubøl 2017). While many other movements are engaged in political contestation against the political insiders seeking to provoke policy change, the refugee solidarity movement is also directly engaged in humanitarian relief efforts. This arguably constrains frame disputes because these disputes are always bordering on an illegitimate divergence from the relief efforts; they risk shifting the focus, as we discussed above concerning the critique of the critique.

One empirical manifestation of this principle is the constant qualification used together with the critique of discrimination. This qualification states that the activists naturally should help Ukrainian refugees as much as possible and then criticize the differential treatment of refugees. The quote opening this section is an example of this. The comments start with a qualifier that seeks to preempt critique of ignoring the suffering humans here and now for the long-term political goals and interests: "Ukrainian refugees have been received with goodwill, a provisional law, and open arms. That is how it should be, in my opinion." It then turns to the critique of the way other refugees have been treated: "But refugees from other wars in the world have in the last couple of years been received with distrust, populist legislation and closed doors, and that is unacceptable from our side." This is not a critique of helping Ukrainian refugees but of the lack of support of other refugees, an attempt to extend the compassion and solidarity afforded Ukrainian refugees to compassion and solidarity with all refugees. Thus, cautious attempts to argue for the value of universalism must assert unconditional care and compassion for the Ukrainian refugees as deserving if their arguments universalizing this compassion to all refugees is to have any weight and are not simply dismissed as an irrelevant distraction from the matter at hand—helping refugees—and thereby as a transgression of the fundamental group norms.

To wrap it up, we hypothesize that frame disputes do not arise as expected but are compartmentalized due to situational and moral constraints on critique. This points toward more research into the constraints to frame disputes within movements and the alternatives to voicing critique that activists turn to, including the potential of compartmentalization. We touch upon these perspectives in our discussing and concluding remarks below.

Discussion and Conclusion

In this article, we have detailed the different cohorts of activists in the refugee solidarity movement's responses to the Danish state's differential treatment of refugees fleeing the 2022 war in Ukraine by showing how moral constraints on critique shape framing disputes between micro-cohorts (Benford 1993; Melucci 1989; Snow, Rochford, et al. 1986; Taylor and Whittier 1992; Whittier 1997), thereby also adding to our understanding of the importance of morality to social movement dynamics (Sevelsted and Toubøl 2023a, 2023b). We have focused on the veteran and new-comer cohorts' differences in evaluation of the provisional law. Using Facebook data, we are able to contribute a rare large-scale study of the ongoing online in-situ interaction between rank-and-file movement members. Thereby the study contributes a valuable supplement to the elite bias in studies of movement framing (Benford 1997; Seigler et. al 2025).

We found clear differences in the moral position of the two cohorts. On the one hand, the veteran cohort was highly critical of the differential treatment, in many cases critiquing Danish policies for discriminating against Muslims and refugees of color and being systematically racist. Some parts of the new-comer cohort, on the other hand, justify the differential treatment with reference to either 1) the difference in the situation (the war in Ukraine is different from the one in Syria), 2) a difference in regional proximity, and 3) a difference in the type of refugee, arguing that Ukrainian refugees are more deserving than refugees from other regions. The new-comer cohort uses deservingness arguments to justify helping some refugees and not others, thereby introducing conditionality of who deserves help and protection, which is in direct opposition to the hitherto dominant value of universalism in the refugee solidarity movement.

The simultaneous presence of different cohorts with very different moral positions should make us expect frame disputes within the movement. However, despite these favorable conditions, we found few frame disputes within the movement. To a large extent, the veteran cohort kept their critique of the government's discriminatory policies outside of the Ukrainian

refugee support groups. We interpret this as compartmentalization within the refugee solidarity movement, where critique is left out of the humanitarian relief settings and voiced in other fora like their own profiles or older groups only inhabited by members of the veteran cohort. We, furthermore, show examples of the difficulty of critiquing under these conditions: The moral grounds for criticizing the differential treatment of the refugees are overruled by the movement's central moral raison d'etre: to alleviate the suffering of refugees. Internal conflict over the issue of differential recruitment might disrupt operations to this end and are therefore morally unacceptable, leading to the compartmentalization of critique into fora where such critique can be voiced without endangering the humanitarian operation.

Our results stem from ongoing online observations of digital trace data, and there are several limitations to this approach. One qualitative limitation concerns our lack of interview data, which could have strengthened our understanding of both cohorts and their experiences of the situations under study. This is particularly relevant for explaining the absence of critique from the veteran cohort in the Ukrainian support groups and for shedding light on the dynamics driving compartmentalization. A second limitation is that we cannot know to what extent critiques of discrimination may have been removed by moderators. Our field observations combined live online ethnography of the movement with retrospective collection of historical data. The latter formed the basis for our quantitative content analysis of critiques of discrimination. However, this data may be subject to survival bias, whereby non-critical posts and comments were more likely to remain visible than those critiquing the differential treatment of refugees. From this perspective, our estimates should be regarded as a lower bound. Nevertheless, both the live ethnographic observations and the large-scale content analysis consistently pointed to the rarity of such critique.

This rarity suggests a declining presence of universalist moral logic. From the perspective of the humanitarian movement’s moral foundations, the justifications observed raise an important research question: are we witnessing a shift toward domestic moral evaluations guiding humanitarian efforts—not only at the national political level, but also within parts of the refugee solidarity movement itself? According to Boltanski and Thévenot (2006), the domestic moral regime is rooted in proximity and relatedness, which condition who receives help and support. This stands in contrast to the abstract rights and values of universalism, detached from specific relations and traditions. The domestic moral grammar thus provides a justificatory logic that

underpins many of the arguments made by Danish politicians as well as the frames articulated by the newcomer cohort of refugee solidarity activists. Such a shift would mark a significant break with the movement's historically dominant moral position, which had been grounded in the universalist humanitarian values that became hegemonic in the post–World War II period (Joas 2013), but which in recent decades have been increasingly challenged and marginalized by in-group chauvinistic moral positions (Boltanski 1999). This highlights the salience of internal frame differences sparked by the entry of new micro-cohorts—differences that may have profound consequences for the future trajectory of social movements and for the broader political issues and struggles in which they are engaged.

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